

Skippable Video Interstitial

House Ad for Premium Subscription · Launched Mar 16, 2026 · Updated Apr 14

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Decision: Should we move the skippable video interstitial to production and begin go-to-market preparation? — **Yes, agreed. Commercial team owns GTM (Apr 15).**

VERDICT

- **Retention guardrail passed** — variant tracks within $\pm 1K$ of control across 31 days (+0.3% delta, not significant)
- **70.4% video completion rate** — weighted avg across 184 countries (GAM); 83.3% full-15s completion on front-end events
- **0.37% CTR** — 23,698 clicks to Premium purchase page across 6.47M impressions, driving 320 subscriptions

1. EXPERIMENT DESIGN

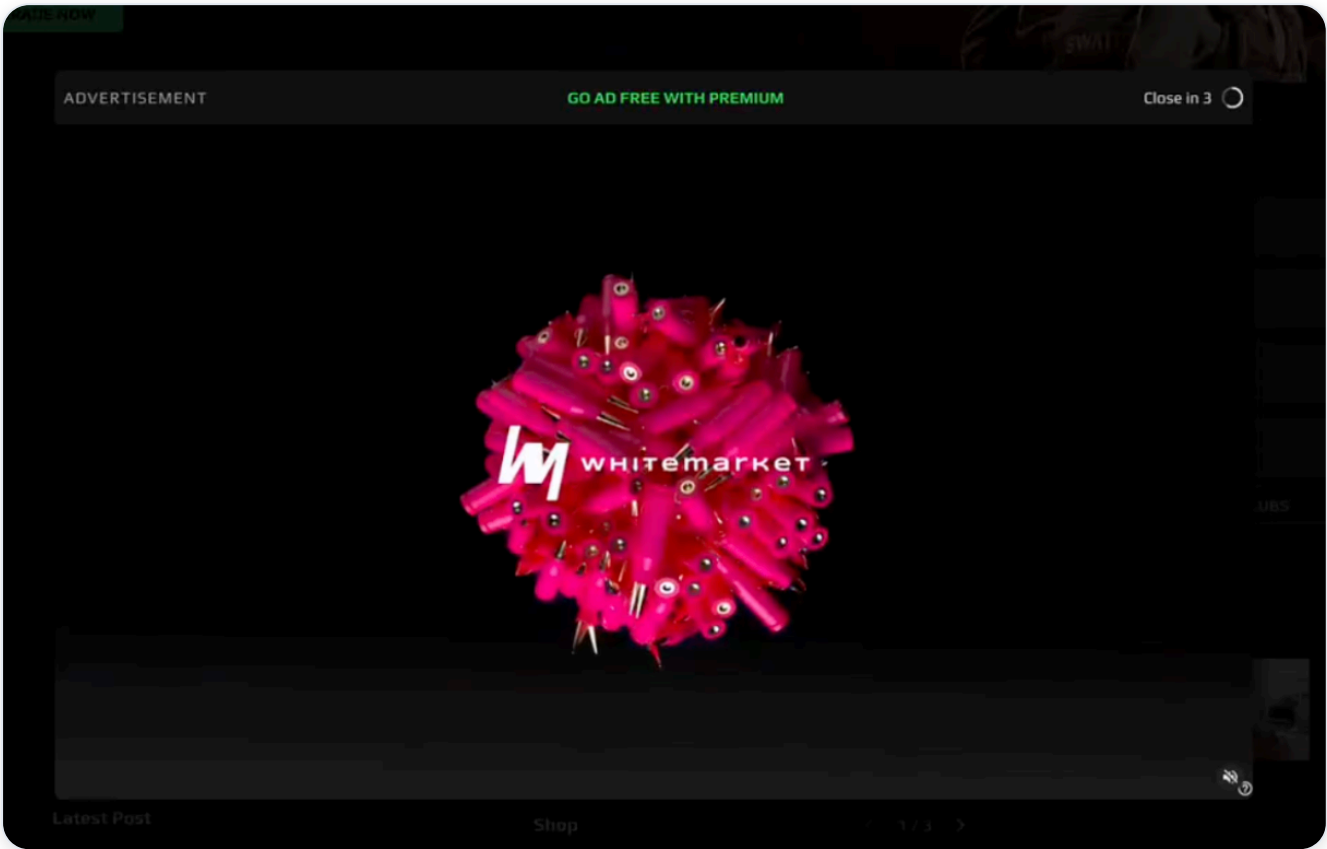
Background

Problem: Interstitial ads deliver our highest CPMs due to strong visibility and CTR, but they are highly intrusive. Increasing interstitial volume risks user frustration, reduced session depth, and long-term CPM degradation. We cannot safely grow revenue by increasing frequency.

Solution: Maintain the same inventory size but increase CPMs by upgrading the creative format — replace static image interstitials with video. Video drives stronger advertiser outcomes (viewability, CTR, brand lift) at the same impression count.

Why skippable: Given the format's intrusiveness, skippable video (3s unskippable, then skip available) balances revenue uplift with user experience. This aligns with established user expectations (YouTube-like behaviour) and preserves advertiser impact in the opening seconds.

Product Preview



Video interstitial overlay on the FACEIT platform. Header shows “GO AD FREE WITH PREMIUM” upsell. Top-right: skip countdown timer with circular progress ring (3s). Bottom-right: mute toggle (autoplay sound-off).

Format Specification

Test Groups

Control

PARAMETER	VALUE
Type	A/B test
Duration	15 seconds
Autoplay	Sound off
Skip available	After 3 seconds
Trigger	User return after inactivity
Placement	Guaranteed in-view interstitial
Fallback logic	Video only shows if no display interstitial fills
Creative	House ad — Premium subscription CTA
Click destination	Premium purchase page

Standard display interstitial (existing behaviour)

Variant

Skippable video interstitial: 3s unskippable, then skip button appears. 15s total duration.

Success Metrics

TYPE	METRIC
Primary	CPM uplift vs static interstitial baseline
Primary	Viewability & CTR
Guardrail	Games played / matchmaking uniques (no negative impact)

Key Design Choice

No Paid Cannibalisation

The video interstitial only fires when **no display interstitial fills** from the programmatic waterfall. This means every video impression is *incremental* — it monetises previously unfilled inventory rather than displacing higher-CPM paid ads.

2. OVERVIEW

GAM IMPRESSIONS

6.47M

Mar 26 – Apr 14
(20 days)

GAM CLICKS

23,698

Click → Premium
purchase page

CTR

0.37%

Clicks /
Impressions

GAM COMPLETION
RATE

70.4%

Weighted avg
across 184
countries

FE: COMPLETED

4.26M

83.3% of FE interactions ·
Full 15s watched

FE: CLOSED / SKIPPED

810K

15.9% of FE interactions

FE: OUTSIDE CLICK

39K

0.8% of FE interactions

Note: FE events (5.11M total) cover ~79% of GAM impressions (6.47M). Gap is expected — GAM fires on ad request, FE fires on user interaction with the player UI.

Premium Subscription Conversions (Affiliate Link)

DIRECT SUBS

46

Clicked video CTA →
subscribed immediately

ASSISTED SUBS

274

Saw ad, subscribed later
(view-through)

TOTAL ATTRIBUTED

320

Direct + assisted · via
affiliate link tracking

Direct: user clicked the video ad CTA and purchased Premium in the same session. **Assisted:** user was exposed to the ad but converted later without a direct click (view-through attribution via affiliate link).

3. EXPERIMENT GUARDRAIL — RETENTION IMPACT

A/B test: **exp_VIDEO_INTERSTITIAL_AD** · Mar 14 – Apr 13, 2026 · Metric: *Uniques of CS2 Active Matchmaking Player* (free users only — memberships filter excludes csgo, plus, etc.)

VARIANT — WITH_VIDEO_INTERSTITIAL

173.3K

Avg daily uniques (past avg: 172.4K)

CONTROL

172.8K

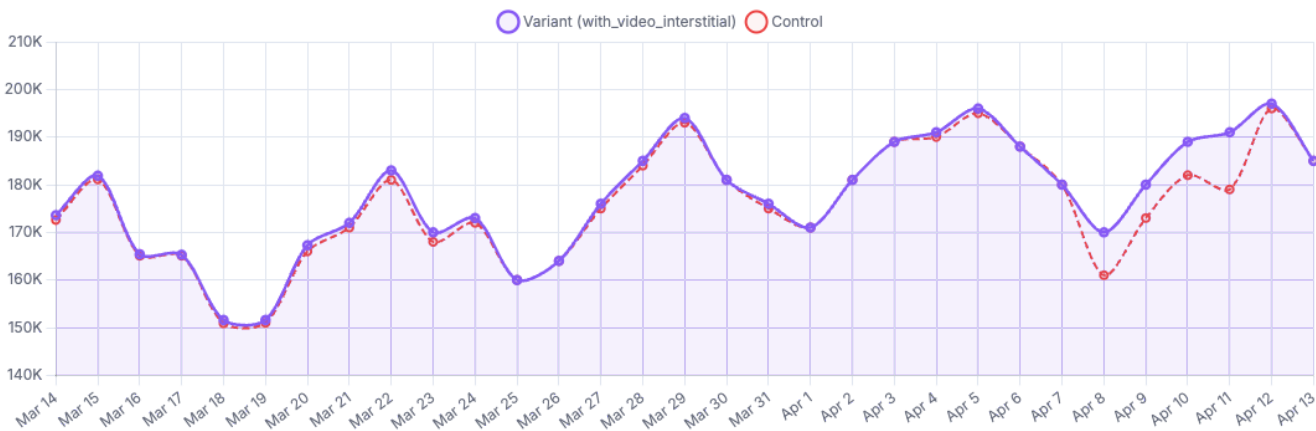
Avg daily uniques (past avg: 171.8K)

DELTA

+0.3%

Variant vs Control

Daily Active Matchmaking Players — Variant vs Control



Source: Mixpanel · Mar 14 – Apr 13, 2026 · Experiment launched Mar 16 (data includes 2-day pre-period). Both lines track near-identically throughout, confirming no retention divergence.

● Guardrail Passed

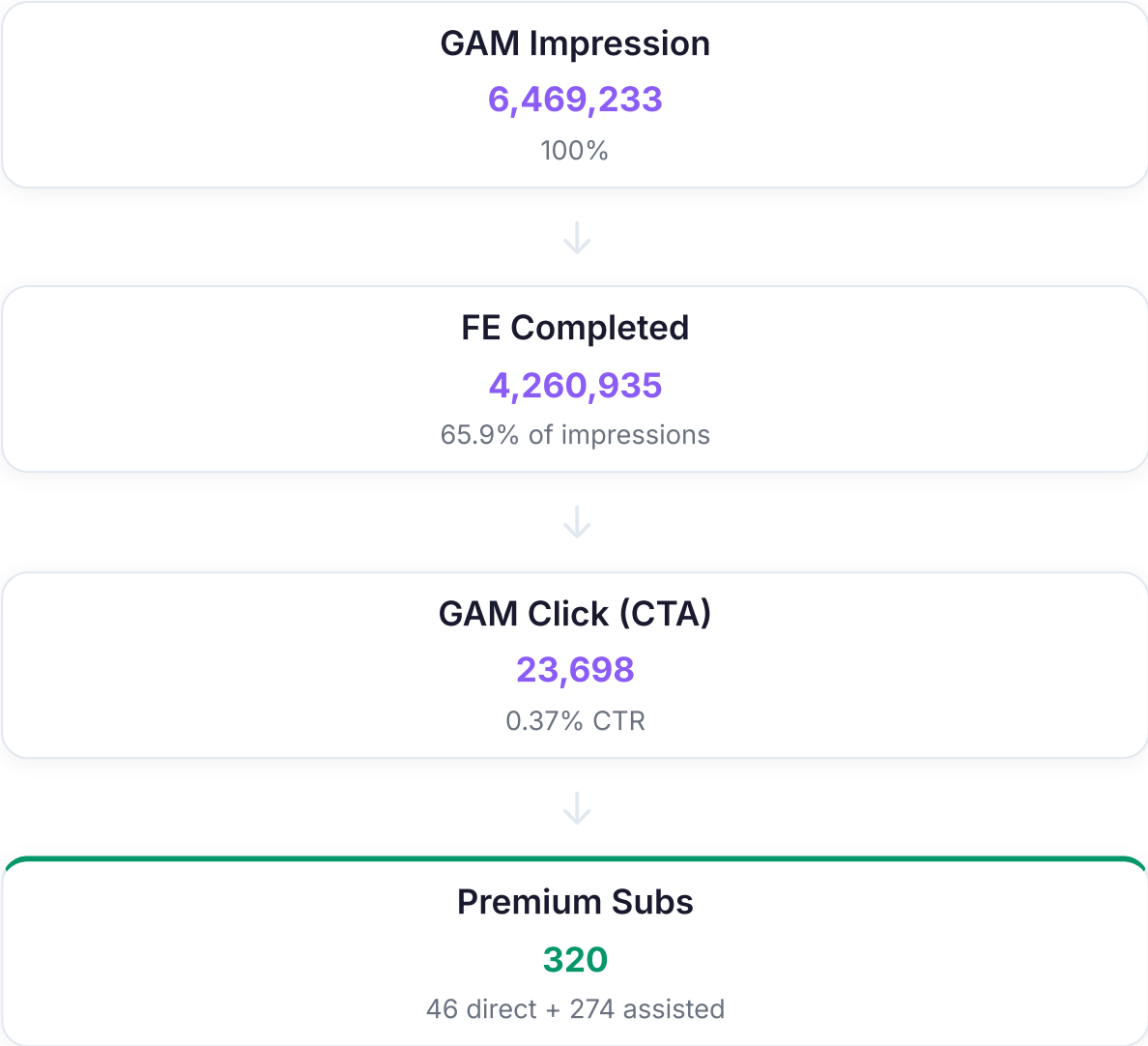
Variant tracks **within ±1K** of control on all 31 days. The +0.3% aggregate delta is not statistically significant — both groups show identical weekly seasonality (Sat/Sun peaks at ~190–197K, midweek troughs at ~151–165K). No retention divergence detected at any point in the experiment window.

Weekly Pattern

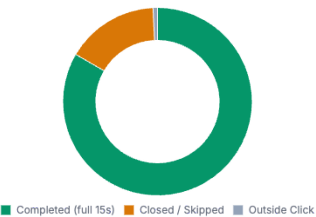
Both groups exhibit a strong **7-day cycle**: matchmaking uniques peak on weekends (Sat 190K+) and trough midweek (Tue/Wed ~151–165K). The video interstitial does not dampen or shift this natural engagement rhythm.

4. USER BEHAVIOUR FUNNEL

Impression → Conversion Path



FE Interaction Breakdown



Funnel Drop-off

STEP	VOLUME	% OF IMPRESSIONS	STEP CONV.
GAM Impression	6,469,233	100%	—
FE Completed (full 15s)	4,260,935	65.9%	65.9%
FE Closed / Skipped	810,455	12.5%	—

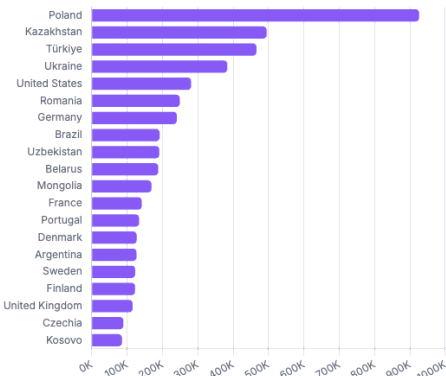
STEP	VOLUME	% OF IMPRESSIONS	STEP CONV.
FE Outside Click	39,057	0.6%	—
GAM Click (CTA)	23,698	0.37%	0.56%
Premium Subscription	320	0.005%	1.35%

Step Conv. for CTA = clicks / FE completed. Subscription step conv. = 320 total subs / 23,698 clicks = 1.35%. Includes 46 direct (clicked → subscribed) + 274 assisted (view-through).

5. AD DELIVERY BY COUNTRY

GAM data: 184 countries · Mar 26 – Apr 14, 2026 · ~323K impressions/day avg

Top 20 Countries by Impressions

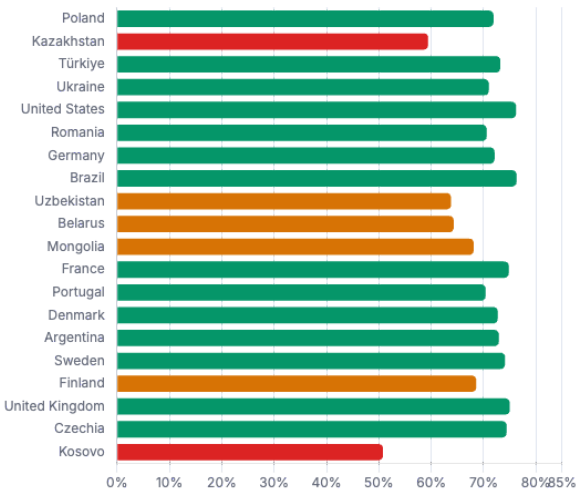


Top 20 Countries — Detail

COUNTRY	IMPRESSIONS	SHARE	CTR	COMPLETION
Poland	925,776	14.3%	0.30%	71.9%
Kazakhstan	494,768	7.6%	0.45%	59.4%
Türkiye	465,820	7.2%	0.36%	73.2%
Ukraine	383,490	5.9%	0.40%	71.0%
United States	281,027	4.3%	0.24%	76.2%
Romania	249,026	3.8%	0.35%	70.6%
Germany	240,921	3.7%	0.30%	72.1%
Brazil	191,978	3.0%	0.26%	76.3%
Uzbekistan	191,135	3.0%	0.47%	63.8%
Belarus	188,082	2.9%	0.43%	64.3%
Mongolia	168,985	2.6%	0.59%	68.1%
France	141,589	2.2%	0.26%	74.8%
Portugal	133,978	2.1%	0.28%	70.4%
Denmark	127,066	2.0%	0.34%	72.7%
Argentina	126,730	2.0%	0.33%	72.9%
Sweden	122,742	1.9%	0.35%	74.1%
Finland	122,564	1.9%	0.27%	68.6%
United Kingdom	115,742	1.8%	0.26%	75.0%
Czechia	89,406	1.4%	0.33%	74.4%
Kosovo	85,534	1.3%	0.89%	50.8%

6. COMPLETION RATE ANALYSIS

Completion Rate by Country (Top 20)



Lowest Completion Rates (≥10K impressions)

COUNTRY	COMPLETION	IMPRESSIONS	CTR
Kosovo	50.8%	85,534	0.89%
Pakistan	55.2%	27,118	0.37%
Albania	56.6%	30,575	0.77%
Tajikistan	57.3%	18,928	0.72%
Kazakhstan	59.4%	494,768	0.45%
North Macedonia	60.8%	47,324	0.59%
Uzbekistan	63.8%	191,135	0.47%
Belarus	64.3%	188,082	0.43%
Kyrgyzstan	64.3%	36,835	0.36%
Azerbaijan	65.5%	14,037	0.45%

Highest Completion Rates (≥10K impressions)

COUNTRY	COMPLETION	IMPRESSIONS	CTR
Taiwan	81.2%	21,069	0.30%
South Africa	80.3%	1,881	0.43%
Malaysia	77.3%	29,072	0.29%
Thailand	77.1%	27,451	0.40%
Hong Kong	77.2%	17,225	0.32%
China	77.2%	18,091	0.46%
Brazil	76.3%	191,978	0.26%
United States	76.2%	281,027	0.24%
Canada	75.7%	68,042	0.27%
United Kingdom	75.0%	115,742	0.26%

Regional Pattern

Central Asian / Balkan countries show notably lower completion rates (50–65%), while APAC and Americas consistently achieve 75–81%. This likely reflects device quality and connection speed differences rather than content relevance.

7. DECISION FRAMEWORK

Key Questions

Does the video hurt retention?

No. Variant (+0.3% daily active matchmaking players) is flat to marginally positive vs control. Guardrail passed.

Do users watch the full video?

83.3% of FE interactions are "completed" (full 15s). GAM weighted completion rate is 70.4% across 184 countries. Strong engagement signal.

Do users click the CTA?

0.37% CTR across 6.47M impressions = 23,698 clicks to the Premium purchase page. These clicks drove **320 Premium subscriptions** (46 direct, 274 assisted via view-through), a **1.35% click-to-subscription conversion rate**.

Is completion rate consistent globally?

71 countries achieve $\geq 70\%$ completion. Central Asia / Balkans dip to 50–65% (likely device/connectivity). APAC and Americas consistently 75–81%.

Next Steps

1. **Guardrail passed** — no retention regression detected. Safe to proceed.
2. Validate CPM uplift: compare video eCPM vs display interstitial eCPM for the same unfilled inventory.
3. Explore replacing house ad with programmatic demand (VAST tags from SSPs) — revenue opportunity.
4. Monitor low-completion geos (Kosovo, Pakistan, Albania) — consider geo-

Go/No-Go Criteria

● GREEN

Guardrail flat/positive
Completion rate $>65\%$
CTR $>0.2\%$
No user complaints

● YELLOW

Guardrail marginally negative ($<1\%$)
Completion 50–65%
CTR 0.1–0.2%

● RED

Guardrail shows retention drop $>1\%$
Completion $<50\%$
Negative user feedback / CS escalations

Current Status

- Retention Guardrail (+0.3%)
- Completion Rate (70.4% GAM / 83.3% FE)
- CTR (0.37%)
- Premium Conversions (320 subs — 46 direct + 274 assisted)
- CPM Uplift (pending — house ad, no revenue comparison yet)
- Go-to-Market (agreed — open questions sent to commercial team, Apr 15)

targeting adjustments if video CPM < display CPM in those markets.

Go-to-Market — Open Questions for Commercial Team

The experiment validated the format on a **new ad unit** using a house ad (Premium subscription CTA). Mandar's team has agreed to take skippable video interstitials to market. The following questions need answers from the commercial side to define the operational model:

1. Ad Serving Setup

The experiment ran as a custom front-end implementation (house ad, no GAM video line item). How should this work in production? Options include VAST tags from SSPs, direct-sold creatives via GAM, or a hybrid approach.

2. Sales & Packaging

How will the sales team position this to advertisers? As a standalone product, bundled with display interstitials, or as part of a broader video package? What's the pitch?

3. Pricing Model

What pricing structure works for the market? CPM floor, fixed rate per campaign, or programmatic-only? The experiment data (70.4% completion, 0.37% CTR) provides the proof points — sales needs to translate this into a rate card.

4. Trafficking & Operations

Who handles creative upload, QA, and campaign setup? Does this fit into the existing ad ops workflow or does it require new tooling / process?

Owner: Mandar's commercial team. PM has validated the format works and there is no

retention risk. The operational go-to-market model is a commercial decision.

Agreed during catchup — Apr 15, 2026.
Mandar will also share the full Salesforce pipeline overview.

Data sources: Google Ad Manager (Mar 26 – Apr 14, 2026), Mixpanel (Mar 14 – Apr 13, 2026), FE Events (all-time through Apr 14, 2026) | Internal PM Tool